

Fatimid architecture

In the 10th to 12th centuries, an area including present-day Algeria, Tunisia, Sicily, Egypt and Syria came under the rule of the Fatimid dynasty who, through their dedication to building and design, triggered a renaissance in the decorative arts and the emergence of a common architectural vocabulary. Cairo (founded 969 CE), the 'City of a Thousand Minarets', became the cultural centre of the Islamic world.

Cairo's first big mosque was Al-Azhar, 'the splendid' (969–73, opposite). It features a hypostyle prayer hall with five aisles, a central courtyard and a stucco exterior showing influences from Abbasid, Coptic and Byzantine architecture. The huge mosque of Al-Hakim (c.996–1013) consists of an open courtyard surrounded by four halls. The mosques of Al-Aqmar (1125) and Al-Salih Tala'i (c.1160) are among the first examples of monumental small mosques, built to serve local needs but still with ornate detail. The Fatimids also developed elaborate tombs, such as those of the Mamluk sultans outside the walls of Cairo.

